Leon Bridges Reinvents His Sound on 'Happiness Anytime'

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Leon Bridges first stepped into the spotlight in 2015 with his **debut** album, Coming Home, a collection of **retro-soul** and R&B songs that became his signature sound. Eleven years later, he is trying something new. His fifth studio album, Happiness Anytime, expands his horizons with **Afrobeats**, Brazilian music and disco.

The change is easy to hear. On the new album, Bridges trades his acoustic guitar for a live band and electronic **accompaniment**, in hopes of making his listeners dance. It is less about sitting back and listening, and more about getting up and moving.

"That's what was beautiful about this album. We didn't know what we wanted to make going into it," Bridges told Morning Edition. "But, you know, it was all about cultivating a new sound. And I felt that."

Bridges added that Happiness Anytime reflects his journey as he continues to become a more complex musician. Speaking with NPR's Michel Martin about the project, he discussed the inspiration he draws from witnessing joy in different cultures, the growth he has experienced since his early career, and the importance of **reinvention**.

That idea - **reinvention** - runs through the whole record. Instead of repeating the **retro-soul** style that first made him known, Bridges mixes it with rhythms and sounds from around the world. The result is an album built around happiness, energy and trying something unfamiliar, even after eleven years of success. For listeners who know him from Coming Home, the new record may sound surprising - and that surprise, Bridges suggests, is exactly the point.

Word Treasure

debut -- A debut is the first time an artist releases work or performs in public.

retro-soul -- Retro-soul is new music made in the style of older soul music.

Afrobeats -- Afrobeats is a popular music style from West Africa with strong dance rhythms.

accompaniment -- Accompaniment is the music played along with a main singer or instrument.

reinvention -- Reinvention means changing yourself or your work into something clearly new.

Background you need

A studio album is a set of new songs recorded and released together, and a debut album is the first one an artist releases.

Retro-soul and R&B are styles rooted in older American popular music, with strong singing and a steady groove.

Afrobeats, Brazilian music and disco come from different musical traditions, so mixing them changes the rhythm and feel of a song.

Reinvention in music means an artist deliberately changes style instead of repeating the sound that first made them successful.

Break it down

LEAD: Leon Bridges releases a fifth studio album with a new sound
KEY EVENT: Happiness Anytime mixes Afrobeats, Brazilian music and disco into his music
+- WHO: Leon Bridges, known since his 2015 debut Coming Home
+- CONTRAST: A live band and electronic accompaniment instead of mostly acoustic guitar
EVIDENCE: Bridges said they did not know what they wanted to make, but it was about cultivating a new sound
OPEN QUESTION: How will listeners who loved Coming Home respond to the surprising change?

Why it matters

Bridges' change shows how artists can keep growing instead of repeating one successful style. It also shows how music borrows rhythms and joy from cultures around the world.

Test what you remember

1. What was Leon Bridges' debut album called?

- (A) Retro-soul
- (B) Coming Home
- (C) Morning Edition
- (D) Happiness Anytime

2. Happiness Anytime is which album in Bridges' career?

- (A) His fifth studio album
- (B) A live album
- (C) His first studio album
- (D) His second studio album

3. Which three styles does the new album bring in?

- (A) Afrobeats, Brazilian music and disco
- (B) Disco only
- (C) Rock, jazz and country
- (D) Classical, blues and folk

4. What does Bridges trade his acoustic guitar for on the new album?

- (A) A live band and electronic accompaniment
- (B) A choir
- (C) A piano played alone
- (D) No instruments at all

5. Who did Bridges speak with about the project at NPR?

- (A) John Swinney
- (B) Michel Martin
- (C) Andy Burnham
- (D) Archie Goodburn

6. What big idea runs through the whole record?

- (A) Staying exactly the same
- (B) Recording at home
- (C) Reinvention
- (D) Retirement

Answer key (try the quiz first!): 1: B 2: A 3: A 4: A 5: B 6: C

Questions to think about

1. Leon Bridges: He said the album was about cultivating a new sound, reflects his journey toward becoming a more complex musician, and draws inspiration from witnessing joy in different cultures.

MY THOUGHTS (at least 20 words):